unique engagement models that fit the customer's specific needs. Bringing in digital solutions not only helps provide a higher level of accuracy and security, continual updates and adhering to compliance regulations, it enables faster processing of claims while keeping a close tab on their status, and has also helped in reducing the number of cases of healthcare frauds.

To up the game, these companies are now actively providing analytics and business insights as a value-add. With the plethora of data and information that is readily available, revenue cycle management service providers can analyse and provide critical actionable insights that would not only help healthcare providers take strategic real-time decisions but also aid in providing an enhanced quality of care. These solutions would require these companies to endorse the cloud and utilise technology to rationalise their costs to a fraction of what it would take to install their own data centres and the related support systems.

Efficient cloud migration is a key element

While demand for IT infrastructure is continuing to grow rapidly, organisations would have to consider migrating their data to the cloud as this would prove to be a more cost-effective and flexible option. Implementation of cloud migration would aid in accelerating digitalisation of an organisation, thus aiding in optimising the business. According to a survey by HIMSS, many healthcare companies now prefer to deploy healthcare applications on the cloud, indicating that trust on the cloud has risen by geometric proportions—in fact, tripling since 2014. This has, hence, enabled many organisations to initiate many critical initiatives.

Though lower setup and maintenance costs are among the key features of cloud storage, organisations can benefit from the flexibility that a cloud data migration can offer.

For instance, imagine a scenario where an online retail company has its annual sale. It would gain a lot of traction from users with more than usual traffic to its website. To keep up with the growing demand, there would be a need for greater Internet bandwidth. It would be better for the company to request its Internet service provider to increase the bandwidth for the said week as a one-off case. However, on other days, the company can continue with its regular limited bandwidth. This kind of flexibility is possible on cloud; but when data is stored in data centres on premise, there is no flexibility. This is why cloud itself is a cost-effective solution since companies do not have to worry about hardware.

However, to take advantage of what cloud has to offer, organisations need to properly plan for the data migration process. It is important to develop a concrete data migration roadmap, which includes deciding which applications and datasets need to migrate to the cloud, and what tools and technologies are available to ease the migration process.

Is data security a concern?

Many organisations have misjudged the sophistication of IT infrastructure involved in deploying cloud. Organisations should start with a strong understanding of the skills and processes required before and after migration of data, across the board, including management and maintenance requirements. Organisations can make migration easier by utilising third-party cloud vendors.

Conforming with governance and regulatory compliance is perhaps the most important aspect to consider in context of cloud migration. Most cloud providers comply with a number of operational security regulations such as SOC2, HIPAA, PCI, etc that provide an insight into protections in place for the provider; however, all of them operate within a shared security responsibility model.

Cloud providers are responsible for security of their own infrastructure; however, security of application is left up to cloud users. Having said that, cloud providers do provide a robust set of tools to manage the security lifecycle of an application, such as identity and access management, security information and event management, network firewalling, log monitoring, etc. It is up to applications to make use of these tools to ensure a robust security profile.

Some other concerns might include cross-border laws (such as General Data Protection Regulation) and multi-tenancy issues, which also warrant careful consideration. Organisations need to understand these aspects in depth before migrating to the cloud, specifically the access control entity, while choosing the third-party vendor(s). Towards this, organisations need to follow a few steps to achieve this.

Country-specific regulations. In the US, enforcement of laws and regulations is stringent, breach of which often attracts severe penalties and can ensnare the offenders in many other complexities. Even today, companies think twice before migrating to the cloud because of the stringent processes, security concerns and the rules they need to comply with.

While choosing a cloud vendor, it is essential to audit for compliance with regulations as per the country's rules and laws. While large companies or organisations are comfortable with adopting cloud-based services, mid-size companies continue to harbor apprehensions with respect to data protection.

It is also imperative for companies to question whether and how they can take advantage of cloud computing while complying with regulations, ensuring privacy and security of data.

Avoiding downtime. Take the case of a company that has a thousand people working on any given client application encountering an IT failure. From the client's perspective, even a one-hour downtime of an operation can result in a loss of a thousand manhours as thousand people were working on it. It is imperative for the company to ensure that clients do not face any instances of downtime. However, for revenue cycle management companies, cost is not the most critical factor in their operations, but it is the security and quality of services they provide.

Select what you need to migrate. Before moving to cloud, revenue cycle management companies need